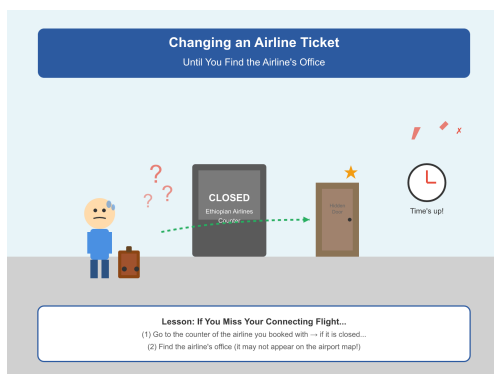


Changing an Airline Ticket

Katsutoshi Seki | Published: December 5, 2025 | Source: <https://sekika.github.io/2025/12/05/AirTicket-trouble/>

Because I missed my connecting flight, I had to change my ticket at São Paulo airport, and the process turned out to be quite troublesome. I'm writing this down as a record for future reference.

To state the conclusion first: if you miss your connecting flight, the procedure is to find the counter of the airline operating your international flight; if the counter is closed, you then locate the airline's office. However, depending on the airport, even the official map may not show where airline offices are located, and airport staff may tell you they "don't know." Even so, you have to persist and find it yourself. Illustration by Claude:



There are several airlines that fly between Tokyo and Rio de Janeiro, but I chose the cheapest option I found online, Ethiopian Airlines, booked through Google → Booking.com. The itinerary was Haneda (Tokyo) → Addis Ababa → São Paulo, then a domestic flight to Rio de Janeiro after entering Brazil. I left Haneda on May 4, 2025, arriving at [São Paulo/Guarulhos International Airport](#) on May 5 at 16:20 on Ethiopian Airlines flight ET506, then connecting to [Gol Airlines](#) flight G31924 departing at 18:00 for Rio. Even at the time of booking, I felt that 1 hour 40 minutes was a risky connection for an international arrival, but among the options presented, this was still the longest layover, so I decided to take it.

The plane landed only slightly behind schedule, and when I joined the immigration line it wasn't yet 17:00. The line didn't look too long; I thought I might make it. However, the line barely moved. There were many booths, and although staff were sitting inside most of them, they were either staring blankly or chatting among themselves. Only one or two booths were actually processing arrivals. Even those seemed to be taking unusually long with each traveler, and the line did not move at all. At that moment I remembered, "Right, this is Brazil."

After finally clearing immigration and collecting my luggage, I walked to the check-in counter for the connecting flight (Counter C in [Terminal 2](#)). This, however, was difficult to locate. After repeatedly asking staff for directions and walking a long distance, I arrived shortly after 17:30, 30 minutes before departure. I showed my ticket to the counter staff and explained that the departure time was close. They told me, "This flight has already closed check-in. You need to talk to the Ethiopian Airlines and have your ticket changed."

So I went to Counter D, where Ethiopian Airlines has its counter. However, since there were no more Ethiopian flights that day, the counter was closed. I asked a staff member standing nearby; they said, "Check-in of Ethiopian Airlines has already finished for the day, so you need to go to the Ethiopian Airlines office to get your ticket changed." They gave me directions, and I headed there.

But when I arrived at the supposed location, there was no sign of the Ethiopian Airlines office. I then asked several nearby staff and workers at the information desk, saying, "I was told there is an Ethiopian Airlines office around here. Do you know where it is?" All of them replied, "Ethiopian Airlines is at Counter D." I explained, "I already went to Counter D, but the counter is closed. I heard there is an office near here." Many staff members didn't speak English, and in those cases I asked them to call someone who could; but in the end, the answer was always, "I don't know."

Next, I went to the Gol Airlines office. I told them, "The Ethiopian Airlines counter is closed, so I want to take a different Gol flight to Rio today. I'm willing to buy a new ticket." They replied, "That's possible, but if you don't take the Gol flight you purchased through Ethiopian Airlines, it will count as a 'no-show,' and all your return flights will be voided. You must get Ethiopian Airlines to make the change." Indeed, having to repurchase all the return flights would be a problem.

Unable to find the Ethiopian Airlines office, I wandered around the airport wondering if I was stuck. Then, finally, I found an inconspicuous door. Behind it was a corridor lined with various airline offices. Notably, this location was not shown on the [official map](#), perhaps intentionally so. I knocked on the door, and an Ethiopian Airlines staff member appeared. After I explained the situation, they changed my flight, and I was able to board another airline's flight departing at 20:15. There was no additional charge.

After all the trouble, it felt great to finally unwind and enjoy Copacabana Beach.

